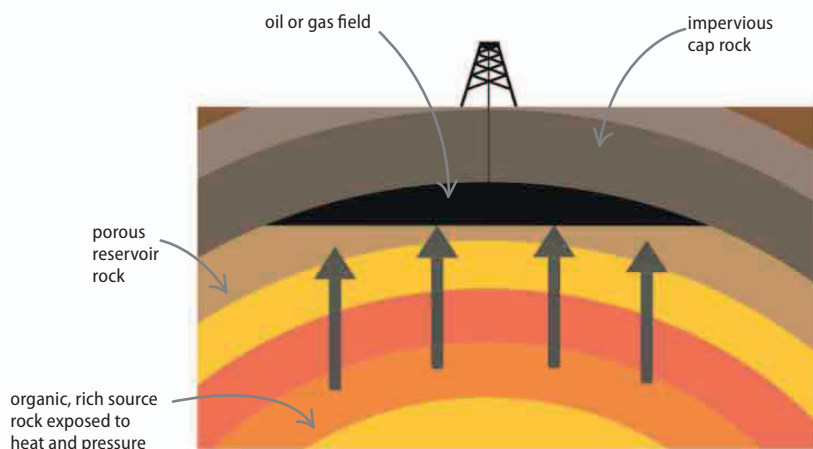


Petroleum

Petroleum—meaning “rock oil”—is a mixture of natural compounds known as hydrocarbons, which are made from carbon and hydrogen. Petroleum forms from a thick ooze of dead microorganisms that covered the beds of ancient seas. After being buried by other sediments, the biological material broke down into hydrocarbons over millions of years.

▷ Oil and gas fields

Petroleum oil or gas is a natural product that percolates up through porous rocks to the surface. When the petroleum’s passage is blocked by nonpermeable rock, it accumulates as an oil (or gas) field.



Crude oil distillation

The mixture of hydrocarbons collected from underground reservoirs of petroleum is known as crude oil. It contains thousands of mostly liquid compounds—the gas given off is known as natural gas. Crude oil is separated into useful fractions: groups of compounds that have similar boiling points, indicating that their molecules have a similar size.

▷ Fractional distillation

Oil is separated in a fractionating tower. The oil is heated and most of it boils and rises upward as vapor. It cools as it rises, and each fraction condenses at a certain height up the tower.

